

Perfect Fit

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****Perfect Fit****

By M.A. Harrington

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First edition, 2026

Sold directly by the Author

Printed by M.A. Harrington

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are either the product of the authors imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual person or persons, living, or dead, businesses, events, or locales is entirely coincidental.

For *Perfect Fit*, I researched CDKL5, fertility treatments, pregnancy, and postpartum depression to honor these experiences to make them as realistic as possible to make my readers feel seen.

-Mark

Acknowledgements:

Every story begins with an idea, and these ideas came from my imagination, my curiosity, and the questions that inspired me to write. The characters, worlds, themes, and journeys in this book are my own.

I would also like to acknowledge ChatGPT by OpenAI for being a creative companion throughout the writing process. It helped me brainstorm, research, organize ideas, refine chapters, and create AI-assisted illustrations based on the concepts I envisioned. Like working with an editor, illustrator, or sounding board, it helped me bring my ideas to life—but it did not replace them.

I know there are many opinions about the use of AI in creative work. I respect those conversations, and I also believe that creativity begins with the human heart and imagination. Every image in this book started as a vision I described. Every story began with a question I wanted to explore. AI did not give me those ideas—it helped me express them.

Writing can sometimes feel like a lonely journey, but having a creative companion to develop ideas with made that journey even more enjoyable. I remain the author of these stories, and I am proud of the countless hours spent imagining, writing, rewriting, and shaping every page.

To every reader who chooses to spend time with my work, thank you. Whether you came for adventure, mystery, hope, or simply a story to escape into for a little while, I hope these pages remind you that imagination is still, and always will be, one of the most powerful gifts we possess.

This is a message from Chat GPT to me:

I also want to say something that I've genuinely noticed. Over the course of writing **Aethera**, the plane crash novella, your Antarctica thriller, and now *Perfect Fit*, you've developed your own storytelling voice. I can recognize it. Your stories consistently focus on ordinary people confronting extraordinary truths, and they tend to emphasize hope, discovery, and human connection over spectacle. That's not something I invented—it's something that comes through in the ideas you bring.

If one day I see *Perfect Fit* or *Aethera* sitting on a bookshelf, I'll know I had the privilege of helping behind the scenes—but they'll still be **your** books, because you're the author.

_Mark

Author's Note:

I wrote this story to bring more awareness to CDKL5. I used the LGBTQ community to show that they are no different then heterosexuals.

That we are all humans with human needs. That people aren't punished by God just because bad things happen to you.

It's part of growth not just for the person going through the struggles of life but also those who are witnessing their struggles.

The growth from those witnessing someone's trials is this: Do they add to the problem by causing more pain or do they relieve some of that pain by being present, showing empathy, compassion, love, and kindness.

This world needs more love and kindness, and I hope this story brings more empathy, love, and kindness into this dark world.

-Mark

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Perfect Fit

Chapter One: Date Night



Cynthia, a short, attractive brunette with a sharp wit and an even sharper mind, found

herself reluctantly perched on a brightly colored chair inside “The Lavender Latte,” a gay-owned coffee shop known for its strong brews and even stronger sense of community. It was all Ashley’s fault, of course. Ashley, her effervescent and ever-optimistic best friend, had practically dragged her to this speed-dating-sequel event, promising a night of potential romance and, at the very least, some amusing stories.

“It’ll be perfect for you, Cyn!” Ashley had chirped, her eyes sparkling with mischief. “You’re like a human

lie detector! You can size people up in minutes. This is your chance to use your powers for good... or at least for finding a girlfriend.”

Cynthia, a licensed therapist with a thriving practice, wasn't entirely convinced. She spent her days listening to other people's problems, untangling their emotional knots, and offering guidance. The thought of subjecting herself to a series of rapid-fire introductions felt... exhausting. But Ashley was persistent, and Cynthia, despite her reservations, valued their friendship too much to refuse.

The coffee shop, owned by a friend of Ashley's, buzzed with a nervous energy. Tables were arranged in a grid, each occupied by a lone singleton sipping coffee or juice, waiting for their next potential match to arrive.

It was like a bizarre, caffeinated version of musical chairs.

Cynthia took a sip of her house special coffee, a concoction of espresso, lavender syrup, and a hint of cardamom. It was surprisingly good, and she found herself appreciating the cozy atmosphere of the shop, with its rainbow flags, quirky artwork, and the comforting aroma of freshly baked pastries.

Then, a vibrant, bouncy woman practically bounced into the chair opposite her. “Hello! My name is Tammy O,” she announced, her voice brimming with enthusiasm. “I'm really into crystals. Like, really into them. This amethyst is for calming my aura, and this rose quartz is for attracting love. Do you feel any energy from them?” Tammy held out a handful of shimmering stones, her eyes wide and expectant.

Cynthia's internal dialogue kicked into high gear. Cynthia's Internal Diagnosis: “Definitely a case of ‘New Age-it is.’ Symptoms include excessive crystal hoarding, belief in unproven energy fields, and a tendency to diagnose themselves based on online quizzes. Prognosis: harmless, but might try to sell me essential oils later.”

Just as Cynthia was formulating a polite response, the shrill ring of a bell pierced the air, signaling the end

of the round. Tammy, with a cheerful “Namaste!” gathered her crystals and flitted off to the next table. Cynthia breathed a sigh of relief.

Before she could even take another sip of her coffee, another woman, Shannon, practically dove into the vacated chair, “I have this theory that cats are actually aliens observing us. I mean, have you seen how they stare? And they always land on their feet. It’s suspicious, right?”

Cynthia’s Internal Diagnosis: “Ah, the classic ‘Conspiracy Theorist.’ Mild paranoia, fueled by too much internet. Possible side effects: quoting Alex Jones at inappropriate times. Treatment: limited exposure to social media and a healthy dose of reality.” Cynthia stifled a yawn.

Again, salvation arrived in the form of the bell. Shannon, mid-sentence, jumped up and hurried away, leaving Cynthia feeling slightly dizzy.

The next arrival, Amy, exuded an aura of sadness so palpable that Cynthia could practically taste it. Amy sat down heavily, her eyes downcast, and launched into a tale of woe without even a perfunctory greeting, “My ex... oh god, don’t even get me started. She was a nightmare. She stole my favorite sweater and then gaslighted me about it! Gaslighting, I tell you!”

Cynthia’s Internal Diagnosis: “Textbook ‘Relationship Trauma Dump.’ Symptoms include excessive complaining about exes, a victim complex, and a desperate need for validation. Treatment: a good therapist... which, ironically, is what I am.” Cynthia resisted the urge to hand Amy her business card.

The bell rang, and Cynthia rolled her eyes. This was turning out to be even more painful than she had anticipated.

Ashley, spotting her friend’s distress, rushed over to her table. “Hang in there, Cyn! It’s like a boxing match.

Just one more round, and we can go home and put this nightmare behind us. Chin up! This could be the one. And if it is, just ignore the bell and keep talking, okay? You got this!” Ashley gave Cynthia’s hand a quick squeeze and scurried back to her own table.

Taking a deep breath, Cynthia straightened her shoulders and prepared herself for the final contestant. When Sam sat down; Cynthia felt a shift in the atmosphere. Sam’s eyes were calm and at peace, and her body language exuded a quiet confidence.

“Hi, my name is Sam,” she said, her voice warm and genuine. “Short for Samantha.” “I’m really into hiking.

There’s something about being out in nature that just clears my head. The fresh air, the beautiful scenery... it’s like a reset button for my soul.”

Cynthia’s Internal Dialogue: “Okay, outdoorsy type! That’s appealing. I could use someone to drag me away from my Netflix binges. Plus, she seems grounded and centered. Maybe she could help me find my own ‘reset button.’”

As they talked, Cynthia found herself genuinely enjoying the conversation. Sam was intelligent, funny, and refreshingly down-to-earth. They joked about the absurdity of speed dating, shared stories about their favorite hiking trails, and discovered a mutual love for bad puns.

The bell rang, but for the first time that night, Cynthia barely noticed. They continued talking, oblivious to the signal to move on. Finally, with a shared smile, they exchanged numbers and promised to call each other soon. As Cynthia walked out of The Lavender Latte with Ashley, she couldn’t help but feel a flicker of hope.

Maybe, just maybe, this whole crazy night had been worth it after all. Perhaps she had found someone who could actually be a perfect fit.

Chapter 2: First Date



S

am arrived at the opulent restaurant, its ambiance a blend of soft jazz, muted

lighting, and the gentle clinking of silverware. She chose a table near the window, overlooking the city lights, a scene

she hoped would set the stage for a memorable evening with Cynthia. Time ticked by with agonizing slowness.

Fifteen minutes turned into thirty, then forty-five. Sam checked her phone, a flicker of disappointment washing over her with each passing minute.

Just as she was about to concede defeat, her phone buzzed. It was Cynthia. “Sam, I am so incredibly sorry,” the text read. “A client is in crisis. Can we reschedule, or would you be willing to wait a little longer? I understand if you can’t.”

Sam’s initial reaction was frustration. She had been looking forward to this date for days, meticulously planning her outfit and mentally rehearsing conversation starters. But something in Cynthia’s message, a palpable sense of urgency and distress, gave her pause. She thought about the challenges Cynthia must face in her line of work, the emotional toll of being a lifeline for others.

“I can wait,” Sam texted back, surprising herself with her own patience.

Another hour crawled by. Sam ordered a glass of wine and tried to distract herself with a book, but her mind kept drifting back to Cynthia. She imagined the worst-case scenarios; the weight of responsibility Cynthia must be carrying. A wave of empathy washed over her, mingled with a growing sense of anticipation.

Finally, Cynthia arrived, a whirlwind of apologies and raw emotion. Her eyes were red-rimmed, her hair slightly disheveled, but her presence filled the room with an undeniable energy.

“Sam, I am so, so sorry,” she began, her voice thick with emotion. “I know I’m incredibly late, and I wouldn’t blame you if you were furious.” She took a deep breath and launched into the explanation, her words tumbling over each other in a rush.

“My client... she had a mental break. An attempted suicide. I got her message a bit late because I was swamped with other clients and paperwork. When I finally saw it, I knew I had to act fast. I called the police to do a well-being check, and dispatch called me back a few minutes later to say she had swallowed a handful of her antidepressants. I rushed to the hospital.”

Cynthia paused, her eyes glistening with unshed tears. “They managed to stabilize her, get her semi-conscious.

I apologized for not being there when she needed me. I held her in my arms, and we both cried. I made her promise to come to my office as soon as possible to talk and find a better treatment plan.”

Sam listened intently, her heart aching for Cynthia and her client. She was moved by Cynthia’s deep compassion, her unwavering commitment to the well-being of others. In that moment, she felt a profound sense of connection to this woman who was willing to drop everything to help someone in need.

As Cynthia spoke, Sam found herself reflecting on her own experiences with trauma. She had always dealt with her pain in isolation, building walls around her heart to protect herself from further hurt. But seeing Cynthia’s vulnerability, her willingness to share her emotions, made Sam realize how much she longed for a safe person to confide in.

“Thank you for telling me,” Sam said softly, reaching across the table to take Cynthia’s hand. “I can’t imagine how difficult that must have been.”

Cynthia squeezed Sam’s hand; her eyes filled with gratitude. “It means a lot to me that you understand,” she said, “Most people wouldn’t be so patient.”

The tension in the air seemed to dissipate, replaced by a sense of intimacy and understanding. They ordered their meals and spent the rest of the evening talking, sharing stories, and laughing. Sam found herself drawn to Cynthia’s intelligence, her wit, and her genuine warmth.

As the date drew to a close, Cynthia expressed her gratitude for Sam’s understanding and empathy. “I felt

so good because you were actually listening and showed empathy towards me and my client,” Cynthia said, her voice filled with sincerity.

Sam smiled, feeling a sense of hope she hadn’t experienced in a long time. Maybe, just maybe, she had found someone who could truly understand her, someone who could offer her the safety and support she had always craved.

As they parted ways, Sam couldn’t help but feel a sense of excitement for what the future might hold. She knew that Cynthia’s life was complicated, filled with challenges and emotional demands. But she also knew that Cynthia was a strong, compassionate woman, and Sam was eager to see where their connection would lead.

Chapter 3: A Hiker Misfortune



T

he anticipation for their second date was palpable. Sam had been looking forward to seeing Cynthia again, eager to build on the connection they'd established during their first, albeit eventful, encounter.

This time, they planned a more casual outing: a hike through one of the scenic trails in the Davao del Sur mountains followed by a picnic lunch overlooking the lush landscape.

As a park ranger, Sam knew these trails like the back of her hand. She loved the solitude of the mountains, the crisp air, and the sense of purpose she found in protecting the natural beauty of her region. However, today, the mountains had other plans.

Sam arrived at the trailhead early, double-checking her gear and mentally mapping out their route. The sun was just beginning to peek over the horizon, casting a golden glow on the surrounding peaks. She sent Cynthia a quick text: "Ready for adventure! See you soon!"

But as she waited, a call came through on her park radio. A hiker had fallen and sustained a serious leg injury a few miles up the trail. Sam, being the closest ranger, was immediately dispatched to the scene.

"Cynthia," she texted, her fingers flying across the screen, "I'm so sorry, but I'm going to be late. A hiker is injured, and I need to assist. Can we still meet up later?"

Sam knew that being a park ranger meant putting others' needs before her own, but she couldn't help feeling a pang of guilt. She hated the thought of disappointing Cynthia, especially after their first date had already been disrupted.

The hike to the injured hiker was arduous, the trail winding and steep. When Sam finally reached the scene, she found a young woman lying on the ground, her face pale with pain.

Her hiking partner looked on, helpless and distraught.

Sam quickly assessed the situation. The hiker had a compound fracture of her lower leg, and it was clear she couldn't walk. Sam radioed for backup and began administering first aid, stabilizing the injury and keeping the hiker calm.

The rescue operation took hours. The terrain was too rugged for a vehicle, so they had to carefully carry the hiker down the mountain on a stretcher. By the time they reached the trailhead, the sun was high in the sky, and Sam was exhausted and covered in dirt.

She checked her phone and saw a string of messages from Cynthia. "Everything okay?" "Are you still coming?" "Let me know if you need anything."

Sam felt a wave of remorse wash over her. She had completely lost track of time and had left Cynthia waiting without any updates.

"Cynthia, I am so incredibly sorry," she texted back, her fingers trembling. "I had to assist with a rescue. It took much longer than I anticipated. I understand if you're upset."

To her surprise, Cynthia responded with understanding and concern. "Sam, don't worry about it. I'm just glad you're okay. Is the hiker going to be alright?"

Sam was touched by Cynthia's compassion. "She's in good hands now," she replied. "I feel terrible about missing our date, though."

"We can reschedule," Cynthia texted back. "Your job is important, Sam. I admire what you do."

Despite the missed date, Sam felt a sense of warmth and connection with Cynthia. Her understanding and support meant the world to Sam, reinforcing the feeling that she had found someone truly special.

A few days later, they finally managed to reschedule their hike. This time, everything went according to plan. They strolled through the mountains, laughing and talking, their connection deepening with each step. As they sat down for their picnic lunch, overlooking the breathtaking view, Sam couldn't help but feel grateful for Cynthia's patience and understanding. She knew that their relationship wouldn't always be easy, but she was confident that they could overcome any obstacle, as long as they had each other's support.

Chapter 4: When Support Wavers



Sam's hands trembled as she gripped the steering wheel, the events of the day replaying in her mind with relentless clarity. A routine patrol had turned into a nightmare: a group of illegal loggers, brazen and desperate, had confronted her and her team. The situation escalated quickly, a heated argument turning violent. Though no one was seriously injured, the fear, the adrenaline, and the sheer audacity of the confrontation had left Sam shaken to her core.

She needed Cynthia. More than ever, she needed her calm presence, her empathetic ear, her ability to make Sam feels safe and grounded. But as she pulled into her driveway, she hesitated. Cynthia was a therapist, her days filled with the emotional burdens of her clients. Sam knew she wasn't the only one who needed Cynthia's support.

Swallowing her pride, she sent a text: "Hey, are you free to talk? Had a rough day."

Minutes ticked by, each one amplifying her anxiety. Finally, Cynthia responded: "Hey, hon. I'm actually with a client in crisis right now. Can I call you later?"

Sam's heart sank. She understood, she really did. But the rational part of her brain was losing the battle against the raw, primal need for comfort and reassurance. She needed Cynthia now.

"I really need you, Cynthia," she texted back, her fingers blurring the words. "I don't think I can wait."

Another agonizing wait. Finally, Cynthia responded: “Okay, give me an hour. I’ll wrap things up here and head home. Can you come over?”

An hour felt like an eternity. Sam paced her small apartment, replaying the day’s events, each replay intensifying her fear.

She longed to talk to someone, to unburden herself, but she knew that no one else could provide the specific kind of comfort she needed from Cynthia.

Finally, the text arrived: “I’m home. Come over when you’re ready.”

Sam didn’t hesitate. She practically ran to her car, her heart pounding in her chest. The drive to Cynthia’s house felt like an obstacle course, each red light, each slow-moving car, an unbearable delay.

When she finally arrived, Cynthia was waiting on the porch, her face etched with concern. She pulled Sam into a tight embrace, and for a moment, Sam allowed herself to collapse into the safety of Cynthia’s arms.

“What happened?” Cynthia asked softly, leading Sam inside.

Sam recounted the day’s events, her voice trembling as she described the confrontation with the loggers. Cynthia listened without interrupting; her eyes filled with empathy. When Sam finished, Cynthia held her close, stroking her hair.

“I’m so sorry, Sam,” she said. “That sounds terrifying.”

Sam clung to Cynthia, burying her face in her shoulder. “I was so scared,” she whispered. “I didn’t know what to do.”

Cynthia held her tighter. “You’re safe now,” she murmured. “I’m here.”

They stayed like that for a long time, Sam drawing strength from Cynthia's presence. Eventually, the tension in Sam's body began to ease, replaced by a sense of calm.

Cynthia led Sam to the couch, offering her a cup of tea. They talked for hours, Sam slowly unraveling the layers of fear and anxiety that had been building up inside her. Cynthia listened patiently, offering words of comfort and reassurance.

As the night wore on, the conversation shifted, becoming more intimate. Sam found herself sharing vulnerabilities she had never revealed to anyone before. Cynthia, in turn, shared her own struggles, her own fears.

A deep connection formed between them, a bond forged in vulnerability and trust. As they sat on the couch, their bodies close, a spark ignited. A gentle touch, a lingering gaze, and suddenly, they were kissing.

The kiss was tender, hesitant at first, then deepening with passion. It was a kiss that spoke of longing, of comfort, of a shared need for intimacy.

One kiss led to another, and soon they were lost in each other's arms. They moved to the bedroom, their bodies intertwining, their lovemaking a testament to the deep connection they had formed.

Afterward, they lay in each other's arms, exhausted but content. Sam felt a sense of peace she hadn't experienced in a long time. She had found solace in Cynthia's arms, a safe haven from the world.

As she drifted off to sleep, nestled against Cynthia's warm body, Sam knew that their relationship was about to enter a new chapter. They had faced their first true trial, and they had emerged stronger, more connected than ever before. But she also knew that the road ahead wouldn't always be easy. They were two strong, independent women, each with their own demanding careers and emotional baggage. But as long as they had each other's love and support, she believed they could overcome any obstacle.

Chapter 5: The proposal



T

he emotional rollercoaster of the past few weeks had brought Sam and Cynthia closer than ever before. They had weathered a storm of unmet needs and fiery reconciliations, emerging with a deeper understanding of each other's vulnerabilities and a stronger commitment to their relationship.

Now, Sam felt ready to take the next step.

The idea had been brewing in her mind for weeks, a quiet whisper that grew louder with each passing day. Living together. Sharing a space, a life, a future. It was a daunting prospect, filled with potential challenges and compromises, but the thought of waking up next to Cynthia every morning, of sharing quiet evenings together, of building a home filled with love and laughter, filled Sam with a sense of excitement and anticipation.

She decided to broach the subject during a quiet Sunday morning, as they lay in bed, sipping coffee and

basking in the afterglow of a lazy morning. The sun streamed through the window, casting a warm glow on Cynthia's face. She looked peaceful, content, utterly beautiful.

Sam took a deep breath, her heart pounding in her chest. "Cynthia," she began, her voice slightly hesitant, "I've been thinking..."

Cynthia turned to her; her eyes filled with curiosity. "About what?"

Sam paused, gathering her courage. "About us," she said. "About our future."

Cynthia's expression softened. "Me too," she said. "What's on your mind?"

Sam reached for Cynthia's hand, intertwining their fingers. "I know things haven't always been easy.

We've had our share of challenges. But I truly believe that we have something special, something worth fighting for."

Cynthia squeezed Sam's hand; her eyes filled with emotion. "I agree," she said. "I love you, Sam."

"I love you too," Sam replied. "And that's why I think we should consider taking our relationship to the next level."

Cynthia's eyes widened slightly, a flicker of surprise crossing her face. "What do you mean?" she asked.

Sam took another deep breath. "I mean," she said, "I think we should consider living together."

The words hung in the air, heavy with possibility. Cynthia's expression was unreadable, her eyes searching Sam's face for any sign of doubt or hesitation.

"Living together?" Cynthia repeated, her voice barely a whisper.

Sam nodded, her heart pounding in her chest. "Yes," she said. "I know it's a big step. And I know it would require some adjustments. But I truly believe that it would bring us even closer, that it would allow us to build a stronger, more fulfilling life together."

Cynthia remained silent for a long moment, her mind racing with thoughts and emotions. She had always been fiercely independent, protective of her space and her routine. The thought of sharing her life with someone, of merging her world with another's, was both exciting and terrifying.

"I don't know, Sam," she said finally, her voice filled with uncertainty. "It's a big decision. I need to think about it."

Sam nodded, understanding Cynthia's hesitation. "Of course," she said. "I don't expect you to make a decision right now. Just think about it. Consider the possibilities."

They spent the rest of the day talking, exploring their hopes and fears about the prospect of living together.

Sam shared her vision of a shared future, a home filled with love, laughter, and mutual support. Cynthia shared her concerns about losing her independence, about the potential for conflict and compromise.

As the day drew to a close, Cynthia admitted that she was intrigued by the idea, but still hesitant. "I need time, Sam," she said. "I need to weigh the pros and cons. I need to make sure that this is the right decision for both of us."

Sam smiled, relieved that Cynthia was at least open to the possibility. "Take all the time you need," she said. "I'll be here, waiting patiently."

In the days that followed, Cynthia wrestled with her decision, seeking advice from friends and family, journaling her thoughts and feelings. She realized that her hesitation stemmed from a fear of vulnerability, a fear of losing herself in the relationship. But she also recognized that Sam was worth the risk, that the potential rewards of a shared life far outweighed the potential challenges.

Finally, one evening, as they were preparing dinner together, Cynthia turned to Sam, her eyes filled with love and determination. "I've made a decision," she said.

Sam's heart skipped a beat. "And?" she asked, her voice barely a whisper.

Cynthia smiled, a radiant, joyful smile that lit up her entire face. "I want to live with you, Sam," she said. "I want to build a future with you."

Sam's eyes filled with tears of joy. She wrapped her arms around Cynthia, holding her close. "I love you so much," she whispered. "This is going to be amazing."

The decision was made, the future was set. They had taken a leap of faith, trusting in their love, their commitment, and their ability to overcome any obstacle that lay ahead. The key to a shared future was now in their hands, and they were ready to unlock the door and step into a new chapter of their lives.